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AI meets storytelling in Mumbai

My experience at the Mumbai AI Film Festival (MAFF)

—By **Vyom Ramani**

On a rainy Sunday evening, I reached the Royal Opera House in Mumbai with pretty mixed feelings. I've always believed films are meant to move you – to make you feel something real – and honestly, I've never felt that from AI visuals. They look perfect, sure, but there's something cold about them. So, when I walked in, I was curious, a bit skeptical, and very ready to be proven wrong.

The crowd, though, was instantly intriguing. This wasn't your usual film festival audience. There were people talking about "prompt engineering," filmmakers swapping notes about workflows, and a few who had just come because "AI" sounded cool. Some were there to network, some to support friends, and a few like me were just there to see if machines could really tell stories that feel human.

When filmmakers met futurists

What surprised me most was how international it felt. Even though this was the

first-ever AI film festival in India, it wasn't limited to Indian participation.

Before the screenings began, a panel took the stage. The lineup had everyone's attention: Shakun Batra, the director of Kapoor & Sons and one of the first Indian filmmakers to experiment seriously with AI; Karan Anshuman, creator of Mirzapur;



and Tanmay Bhat, the comedian and digital creator who's built an entire persona around understanding online culture.

Their conversation felt pretty candid. They spoke about AI as a collaborator and not a competitor, a creative partner that opens new ways of visualising. But the question that lingered was philosophical: can AI understand emotion, or is it just good at faking it?

There weren't clear answers, but that didn't matter. Everyone there

was just excited to find out what happens next.

The festival premiere itself felt like something out of science fiction. A humanoid robot greeted celebrities as they entered, while robotic dogs walked around interacting with guests.

Ram Madhvani, Shakun Batra, Kunal Kapoor, and Mukul Deora (Oscar-nominated producer of The White Tiger), all evaluating the films for creativity, innovation, and narrative finesse.

Films that looked great, but felt off

Fourteen films in total, each different in tone and ambition. Most were stunning to look at, cinematic lighting, smooth camera moves, detailed frames. But the human touch was visibly missing. Lip-syncs were off, sound was clearly done in post, and scenes felt emotionally flat despite the visual perfection.

AI had given these filmmakers tools to experiment without massive budgets, to make the kind of visuals that, a few years ago, only studios could afford.

It reminded me of early VFX – a little weird, but you see where it was headed. tinyurl.com/jh09d1pc